children playfully, and hugged wizened old ladies who came to bless him. He was soon seen delivering extempore speeches at corner meetings, asking and answering questions in smaller group interactions, and holding press conferences every few days (in sharp contrast to the Prime Minister, who is yet to oblige on Indian soil). Somewhere along the way, the assiduously manufactured ‘Pappu’ vanished into thin air. He reiterated his clear and simple but powerful message from every platform: Unity and harmony, inflation, unemployment, crony capitalism, Adani versus small and medium business, attack on democratic institutions—this is why we need the Yatra.

In a preparatory meeting in Delhi attended by many civil society groups, in reply to a question about why he did not concentrate on fighting elections in the usual way, he had replied: We tried again and again but failed, because everything is stacked against us, the Election Commission, the media, the courts, the police and access to funds. We can’t reach the people in the usual ways that are available in a democracy. That is why we decided to go directly to the people through the BJY. In many ways, he communicated this same understanding to the people throughout the Yatra.

It must also be pointed out that the mainstream media, the national press and the major TV channels ignored the BJY right through. Some relented a little in the latter part of the Yatra, when it reached the national capital, for example. But local Indian-language media did cover it, as did social media and smaller YouTube channels. Despite that, the message spread. The BJY’s social media team provided real-time coverage and put out smaller video reels as well, focusing on interviews with participants, etc. The net result was that it could not be blacked out.

Why am I narrating this story in the way that I am? To give you a feel of what effect it had on the minds and hearts of the Indian people. A lot more research needs to be done to find out its short- and long-term impact.

And now for the smaller story. The microcosm that reflects the macrocosm.

We had two opportunities to observe the BJY at close quarters. The first one was in Telangana on 30 October 2022. We had been following the course of the Yatra since its inception and noting its growing popularity, and